

RIZWAN ZAFAR

Payments Product & Program Executive — Fintech Infrastructure | Emerging & Frontier Markets

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Chief Product Officer with 14+ years building and scaling payment gateway, cross-border and merchant-acquiring products across emerging and frontier markets. At Simpaisa (Singapore HQ), scaled the leading payment-gateway connector for frontier markets from market entry to \$1B+ annual GTV, ~270M annual transactions and a 99.95% settlement SLA across 5 markets. Owns the end-to-end product stack — pay-in, payouts and cross-border — plus the program and PMO discipline that delivers it: multi-squad execution, SteerCo governance and vendor management. Built a product controls environment from scratch (PCI-DSS Level 1 + ISO 27001), audited without findings across 5 regulatory jurisdictions. Local infrastructure partner for DLocal, Thunes, Boku, Coda Payments and Tazapay, enabling global platforms (TikTok/ByteDance, Samsung, Shein, Codashop, Xsolla, Uber, MoneyGram) to land in markets where they have no local rails.

CORE COMPETENCIES

Payment Gateway & Orchestration: Payment gateway · Orchestration · Pay-in · Payouts · Cross-border settlement · Reconciliation · Multi-currency & FX · Dynamic corridor pricing

Merchant & Acquiring: Merchant acquiring · Merchant onboarding (weeks → hours) · Self-service flows · Automated KYC/KYB · Risk-based approval · Blended & IC++ pricing · Merchant of Record

Payment Methods & Rails: Card acquiring (MPGS/MDES) · Tokenization · 3DS2 · Mobile wallets · DCB · IBFT · QR · Bill payments · BNPL · Open banking · Stablecoin settlement

Risk, Compliance & Security: PCI-DSS Level 1 · ISO 27001 · AML/CFT · Fraud prevention · Chargeback management · Multi-jurisdiction regulatory readiness · EMI operations

Product & Program Leadership: Product strategy & roadmap · P&L ownership · Business cases · GTM · PMO governance · SteerCo · OKRs · Vendor management · Org design (2 → 8 PMs, 50+ team)

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Chief Product Officer (and acting CTO, 2024) — Simpaisa

Dubai, UAE (Singapore HQ) | August 2020 – Present

Payment-gateway connector and orchestration platform for frontier markets; enterprise clients include TikTok/ByteDance, Samsung, Shein, Uber and MoneyGram.

- Defined and own the multi-year product strategy and roadmap with the CEO and C-suite across pay-in, payout and cross-border product lines; scaled from market entry to \$1B+ annual GTV across 5 jurisdictions.
- Own the end-to-end pay-in stack — card acquiring (MPGS/MDES), mobile wallets, DCB, IBFT, vouchers, bill payments, QR and tokenization — and the payout stack: switch integration, direct wallet payouts, cash-out and B2B vendor disbursements.
- Drove authorization optimization across issuers and acquirers: 22% token-failure reduction, 14% authorization uplift, and 120K+ failed transactions recovered monthly via smart-retry logic — holding 97% payment success at 90% straight-through processing, with 99.9% platform uptime.
- Designed merchant onboarding end-to-end (self-service flows, automated KYC/KYB, tiered risk-based approval, dynamic pricing by category), cutting onboarding from weeks to hours across 150+ merchants.
- Built fraud prevention, chargeback management and AML/CFT infrastructure; held fraud losses below 0.1% of GTV and settlement SLA at 99.95% across 5 markets.
- Led PCI-DSS Level 1 and ISO 27001 certification programs from scratch — both audited without findings across 5 regulatory jurisdictions.
- Scaled the partnership ecosystem as the local infrastructure layer for DLocal, Thunes, Boku, Coda Payments, Tazapay and Eastnets; established blended and IC++ pricing for enterprise merchants.
- Shipped 4 new market launches in 2024 (Bangladesh, Nepal, Iraq, Egypt) on time and within budget during a regulatory transition, while serving as dual CPO and acting CTO.
- Built and led the product organization from 2 to 8 product managers within a 50+ person cross-functional team; chaired weekly steering committees with internal leads and external partners; reported product KPIs (approval rates, GTV, fraud rate, SLA) to the CEO and board monthly.

Project Manager, Payments Operations — Daraz (Alibaba Group)

Karachi, Pakistan | March 2020 – August 2020

- Ran payments operations and product readiness across 5 markets (Pakistan, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Nepal, Myanmar) during the COVID-driven transaction surge; lifted checkout conversion 15% and settlement accuracy to 99.5%.
- Coordinated multi-country reconciliation, payment compliance, fraud-rule tightening and vendor management at Alibaba scale; cut false declines 20% through 3DS2 policy tuning.

Head of Product & Projects — Tapmad (OTT Streaming)

Karachi, Pakistan | July 2017 – March 2020

- Owned product strategy and monetization for Pakistan's leading OTT platform; designed and launched direct carrier billing with all four major telcos, scaling from 0 to 5M+ paid subscribers in under three years.
- Identified unsustainable unit economics and led the full migration to wallet and card billing — payment cost cut from ~50% to ~1%, ARPU up 70% through pricing and bundle optimization.

Earlier — Program & PMO Leadership

Wing Logic LLC (Dubai) · CIMKO (D.R. Congo) · DS Engineering (Karachi) | 2012 – 2017

- Progressive program-management and PMO-leadership roles across \$8M–\$15M technology and infrastructure portfolios; built PMO governance and reporting that cut delays and improved delivery efficiency up to 70%.

RECOGNITION & PROFESSIONAL LEADERSHIP

Youngest Project Manager of the Year — PMI Karachi (2015) · Vice President (2022–23) and Director, Governance (2021–22) — PMI Karachi Chapter

EDUCATION

MIT Sloan School of Management — Certificate, Mastering Design Thinking (2022)

University of Karachi — M.Sc. Applied Physics (2009–2012); B.Sc. Physics, Statistics & Mathematics (2007–2009)

CERTIFICATIONS

Certified Scrum Product Owner (CSPO), Scrum Alliance (2024) · Certified ScrumMaster (CSM), Scrum Alliance (2024) · Project Management Professional (PMP), PMI (2016) · PMI Agile Certified Practitioner (PMI-ACP), PMI (2021) · COBIT 5 Foundation, ISACA (2019) · ITIL v3 Foundation, AXELOS (2018)